CHAPTER

04

Basic Concepts of Critical Thinking

In high school the emphasis is often on **lower-order thinking**: absorb information and repeat it on tests. University aims at **higher-order thinking**, the active and intelligent evaluation of ideas. As Martin Luther King Jr. put it, *"the function of education is to teach one to think intensively and to think critically."* This chapter covers the **meaning, standards, principles, characteristics, barriers and benefits** of critical thinking.

LESSONS IN THIS CHAPTER

4.1 Meaning of Critical Thinking

4.2 Standards of Critical Thinking

4.3 Codes of Intellectual Conduct for Effective Discussion

4.4 Characteristics of Critical Thinking

4.5 Barriers to Critical Thinking

4.6 Benefits of Critical Thinking

CHAPTER 4 · LESSON 4.1

Meaning of Critical Thinking

AFTER THIS LESSON YOU CAN

- Define critical thinking in the module's words
- Explain why intelligence is not enough
- Compare the definitions of Dewey, Glaser, Ennis, Paul and Scriven
- Explain "criticocreative" thinking

4.1.1 What does "critical thinking" mean?

"Critical" here means *involving or exercising skilled judgment or observation*. It does **not** mean "negative" or "fault-finding".

D CRITICAL THINKING (MODULE DEFINITION)

A wide range of cognitive skills and intellectual dispositions needed to effectively identify, analyze, and evaluate arguments and truth claims; to **discover and overcome personal preconceptions and biases**; to **formulate and present convincing reasons** in support of conclusions; and to make **reasonable, intelligent decisions about what to believe and what to do**.

I IN SIMPLE WORDS

Critical thinking is thinking **clearly, fairly, rationally, objectively and independently**. Its aim is to reach **well-reasoned, considered and justifiable conclusions**, without being swayed by irrelevant emotions.

! SMART ≠ CRITICAL

"It does not automatically follow that being intelligent means being able to think critically... **Being smart and intelligent is not sufficient.**" Critical thinking is a **process or journey**, not a talent you are born with.

4.1.2 Five famous definitions

Thinker	Definition	What it adds
John Dewey	"**Active, persistent and careful consideration** of a belief or supposed form of knowledge **in the light of the grounds which support it** and the further conclusions to which it tends."	Three key words: **active** (not passive), **persistent** (not jumping to conclusions), **grounds** (reasons and implications). *Grounds* are the most important point

Thinker	Definition	What it adds
Edward Glaser	(1) An **attitude** of being disposed to consider problems thoughtfully; (2) **knowledge** of the methods of logical enquiry and reasoning; (3) some **skill** in applying those methods	Uses **"evidence"** instead of "grounds"; adds **attitude/disposition + skill**
Robert Ennis	"**Reasonable, reflective thinking** that is focused on **deciding what to believe or do**."	Adds **decision-making** (choosing a phone, a department...)
Richard Paul	The mode of thinking in which the thinker **improves the quality of his or her thinking** by skillfully taking charge of its structures and **imposing intellectual standards** on them	**Thinking about one's thinking: meta-cognition**
Michael Scriven	"**Skilled and active interpretation and evaluation** of observations and communications, information and argumentation."	Critical thinking is an **academic competency like reading and writing**; includes **interpretation** and **evaluation**

M **LINK EACH THINKER TO ONE WORD**

Dewey → **Grounds** (active, persistent) · **G**laser → **Attitude + skill** · **E**nnis → **Decide** what to believe or do · **P**aul → **Meta-cognition** (thinking about thinking) · **S**criven → **Interpretation** (an academic competency like reading).

4.1.3 "Criticocreative" thinking

Critical thinking is sometimes called **criticocreative** thinking (*critical + creative*), for **two related reasons**:

1. The term "critical thinking" can **sound negative**, as if its only aim were to attack other people's ideas.
2. To evaluate ideas well you must be **imaginative and creative**: think of other possibilities, alternative views, different options and missing information.

★ SUMMARY

Critical thinking is **evaluative thinking** that involves **both criticism and creative thinking**, and is concerned with the **quality of reasoning** offered for a belief or a course of action.

Exam Practice

9 QUESTIONS · LESSON 4.1

1 Jigjiga University · Mid 2016

Critical thinking is the study of general and fundamental problems concerning matters such as existence, knowledge, truth, beauty, law, justice, validity, mind and language.

True / False

2 Salale University · Final 2015

One purpose of critical thinking is to discover and overcome personal preconceptions.

True / False

3 Jigjiga University · Final

All are true EXCEPT:

A) Critical thinking is thinking clearly, fairly, rationally, objectively and independently
B) Being smart and intelligent is sufficient for being a critical thinker
C) The aim of critical thinking is to arrive at well-reasoned, justifiable conclusions
D) Critical thinking is a process that is not swayed by irrelevant emotions

4 Hawassa University · Model Exam

"Active, persistent, and careful consideration of a belief or supposed form of knowledge in the light of the grounds which support it and the further conclusions to which it tends." This definition belongs to:

A) Robert Ennis
B) Richard Paul
C) John Dewey
D) Michael Scriven

5 Hawassa University · Model Exam

Which thinker's definition of critical thinking explicitly emphasizes deciding what to believe or **do** (decision-making)?

A) Glaser
B) Dewey
C) Paul
D) Ennis

6 Arba Minch University · Model Exam

"The only realistic way to develop one's critical thinking ability is through thinking about one's thinking." This idea, called meta-cognition, is emphasized in the definition of:

A) Richard Paul
B) Robert Ennis
C) John Dewey
D) Edward Glaser

7 Arba Minch University · Model Exam

Who argued that critical thinking is an academic competency akin to reading and writing?

A) Martin Luther King Jr.
B) John Dewey
C) Edward Glaser
D) Michael Scriven

8 Debre Berhan University · Model Exam

Critical thinking is sometimes called "criticocreative" thinking because:

A) good evaluation requires imagining alternatives and possibilities
B) it is mainly about attacking others' arguments
C) it rejects logic in favour of creativity
D) it is limited to artistic works

9 Debre Berhan University · Model Exam

In Dewey's definition, the most important point is what he says about the "grounds which support" a belief and the "further conclusions to which it tends."

True / False

Answers & Explanations

1. False

That is the module's definition of **philosophy**. Critical thinking is a wide range of cognitive skills and dispositions needed to identify, analyze and evaluate arguments and truth claims.

2. True

The module says critical thinking "helps to discover and overcome personal preconceptions and biases."

3. B

Being smart and intelligent is sufficient for being a critical thinker

The module says the opposite: "Being smart and intelligent is not sufficient."

4. C

John Dewey

Dewey's definition; its three key points are active, persistent and grounds.

5. D

Ennis

Ennis: "reasonable, reflective thinking that is focused on deciding what to believe or do."

6. A

Richard Paul

Paul defines critical thinking as improving one's thinking by taking charge of its structures and imposing intellectual standards on them.

7. D

Michael Scriven

Scriven defined critical thinking as the skilled and active interpretation and evaluation of observations, communications, information and argumentation.

8. **A**

good evaluation requires imagining alternatives and possibilities

To judge issues well you must be creative about other possibilities and viewpoints. The term also avoids the negative ring of "critical".

9. **True**

The module says the most important point is grounds: what matters are the reasons for a belief and its implications.

CHAPTER 4 · LESSON 4.2

Standards of Critical Thinking

AFTER THIS LESSON YOU CAN

- Define "standard of critical thinking"
- Explain the eight intellectual standards
- Distinguish logical from practical inconsistency
- Match examples to standards

A **standard of critical thinking** is *a condition or level that critical thinking should meet to be considered normal and acceptable*. Critical thinking is **disciplined thinking governed by clear intellectual standards**. The module lists **eight** of them.



"Clear People Always Read Carefully, Logic Comes First"

The eight intellectual standards

Standard	Meaning	Key point or example
1. Clarity	Clear understanding of concepts and expressing them in language **free of obscurity and vagueness**	**The gateway standard**: if a statement is unclear, we cannot judge whether it is accurate or relevant. "What can be done about the education system in Ethiopia?" is unclear. Muddy language can even cost lives (a badly worded road sign: Strunk and White)
2. Precision	Being **exact, accurate and careful**; paying close attention to detail	Precise answers to precise questions: *What exactly is the problem? What exactly are the alternatives?* Vital in medicine, mathematics, engineering
3. Accuracy	Having and getting **true (correct) information**	**John Rawls:** "truth is the **first virtue** of systems of thought." **"Garbage in, garbage out"**: bad information means bad decisions, however brilliant you are
4. Relevance	A question of **connections**: only points that **bear on the issue**	A debater's trick is to raise an irrelevant issue. Two ideas are relevant when they have a **logical connection**
5. Consistency	Always behaving the same way, or having the same opinions or standards	If someone holds inconsistent beliefs, **at least one is false**. Two kinds (below)
6. Logical correctness	**Reasoning correctly**: drawing well-founded conclusions from one's beliefs	Thoughts that are mutually supporting and make sense together are logical

Standard	Meaning	Key point or example
7. Completeness	**Deep and complete** rather than shallow and superficial thinking	(Though a short newspaper editorial can't be expected to discuss an issue in depth)
8. Fairness	**Open-minded, impartial**, free of distorting biases and preconceptions	Treating all relevant viewpoints alike without reference to one's own feelings or interests. Hard, but essential

4.2.1 Two kinds of inconsistency

★ **LOGICAL INCONSISTENCY**

Saying or believing inconsistent things (things that cannot both or all be true) **about a particular matter**.
Example: claiming "morality is relative" while holding views that imply it is **not** relative. (Socrates noted that such unconscious inconsistency is far more common than we suspect.)

! **PRACTICAL INCONSISTENCY**

Saying one thing and doing another.
Example (Harold Kushner): almost everyone says family matters more than money, but watch where they actually invest their time and energy.
Conscious cases are **hypocrisy**, which is a failure of **character**. Unconscious cases show our capacity for **self-deception**, which is the interesting case for critical thinking.

M **QUICK MATCHING FOR EXAMS**

"same way always" → **consistency** · "true information" → **accuracy** · "exact and careful" → **precision** · "free of vagueness" → **clarity** · "deep, not shallow" → **completeness** · "logical connection to the issue" → **relevance** · "impartial, open-minded" → **fairness** · "well-founded conclusions" → **logical correctness**.

Exam Practice

10 QUESTIONS · LESSON 4.2

1 Salale University · Final 2015

Consistency means the quality of always behaving in the same way or of having the same opinions or standards.

True / False

2 Jigjiga University · Final

_____ involves saying or believing inconsistent things (things that cannot both or all be true) about a particular matter.

A) Practical inconsistency
B) Logical inconsistency
C) Logical correctness
D) Completeness

3 Salale University · Final 2014

Match: (1) the quality of always performing in the same way; (2) having and getting true information; (3) thinking deep rather than shallow; (4) a matter of being exact and careful; (5) understanding concepts and expressing them in language free of vagueness. Options: A. Clarity, B. Accuracy, C. Relevance, D. Completeness, E. Precision, F. Consistency.

4 Salale University · Final 2014

Fill in the blank: "_____ refers to the conditions or level that critical thinking should meet to be considered normal and acceptable."

5 Mekelle University · Model Exam

Which standard of critical thinking is called the "gateway" standard, because without it we cannot judge any other standard?

A) Accuracy
B) Fairness
C) Relevance
D) Clarity

6 Mekelle University · Model Exam

"Garbage in, garbage out" best illustrates the importance of:

A) Fairness
B) Completeness
C) Accuracy
D) Precision

7 Jimma University · Model Exam

"Truth is the first virtue of systems of thought." This statement, used to explain the standard of accuracy, is from:

A) Strunk and White
B) Socrates
C) John Rawls
D) Harold Kushner

8 Jimma University · Model Exam

A health officer tells people to stop smoking while he himself smokes every day. This is an example of:

A) Lack of precision
B) Lack of completeness
C) Logical inconsistency
D) Practical inconsistency

9 Woldia University · Model Exam

"Treating all relevant viewpoints alike without reference to one's own feelings or interests" describes the standard of:

A) Logical correctness
B) Consistency
C) Fairness
D) Relevance

10 Woldia University · Model Exam

According to the module, if a person holds logically inconsistent beliefs, at least one of those beliefs must be false.

True / False

Answers & Explanations

1. **True**

This is the module's exact definition of consistency.

2. **B**

Logical inconsistency

Practical inconsistency is saying one thing and doing another. (The original paper's option read simply "Inconsistency".)

3. **1-F, 2-B, 3-D, 4-E, 5-A**

Relevance (C) is not used.

4. **Standard of critical thinking**

The module's definition at the start of Lesson 2.

5. **D**

Clarity

If a statement is unclear we cannot tell whether it is accurate or relevant; we do not yet know what it says.

6. **C**

Accuracy

Bad (false) information leads to bad decisions, however brilliant the thinker. Accuracy means having true information.

7. **C**

John Rawls

Rawls, in A Theory of Justice: a theory, however elegant, must be rejected or revised if it is untrue.

8. **D**

Practical inconsistency

Saying one thing and doing another is practical inconsistency. If he does it knowingly, it is hypocrisy (a failure of character).

9. **C**

Fairness

Fairness means open-minded, impartial thinking, free of distorting biases.

10. **True**

"Logic tells us that if a person holds inconsistent beliefs, at least one of those beliefs must be false."

CHAPTER 4 · LESSON 4.3

Codes of Intellectual Conduct for Effective Discussion

AFTER THIS LESSON YOU CAN

- Explain the five principles of a good argument
- Explain why "acceptable" is preferred to "true"
- Explain the seven principles of critical thinking
- Link principles to fallacies

The codes of intellectual conduct have two parts: **principles of a good argument** (5) and **principles of critical thinking** (7).

4.3.1 The five principles of a good argument

Principle	Requirement	Simple test
1. Structural	The argument must meet the **structural requirements of a well-formed argument**: no reasons that **contradict each other** or the conclusion, no **assuming the conclusion**, no invalid deductive inferences	*Does it look and work like an argument?* Incompatible premises can "prove" anything; a conclusion that contradicts a premise violates the **law of non-contradiction**
2. Relevance	Give only reasons **whose truth provides some evidence** for the conclusion	Would the premise being true make me more likely to believe the conclusion? Should it count at all?
3. Acceptability	Give reasons **likely to be accepted by a mature, rational person** and that meet standard criteria of acceptability	Would a rational person accept it in the face of all the relevant evidence?
4. Sufficiency	Give relevant and acceptable reasons **of the right kind, sufficient in number and weight**	Enough reasons? Faulty causal analysis? Key evidence missing? (Assigning **weight** is the hardest part)
5. Rebuttal	Include an **effective rebuttal to all anticipated serious criticisms**	Does it answer the strongest counterarguments?

M "S-R-A-S-R": "SMART READERS ALWAYS SPOT REASONS"

Structure · **R**elevance · **A**cceptability · **S**ufficiency · **R**ebuttal. In Chapter 5, fallacies of **relevance** break principle 2 and fallacies of **weak induction** break principle 4 (sufficiency).

WHY "ACCEPTABLE" INSTEAD OF "TRUE"? (4 REASONS)

1. In real discussions, agreement on the conclusion comes from **acceptance of the premises**.
2. It is **notoriously difficult to establish absolute truth**; demanding it would leave very few good arguments.
3. In ordinary language, "true" often means **"accepted as true"** (contradictory witnesses each "tell the truth").
4. Even a true premise may be **unacceptable to an audience** that cannot check it (too technical).

REBUTTAL DODGES

Arguments fail the rebuttal principle by **misrepresenting** the criticism, raising **trivial objections or side issues**, using **humor or ridicule**, **ignoring or denying counterevidence**, or **attacking the critic** instead of the criticism.

4.3.2 The seven principles of critical thinking

Principle	Requirement
1. Fallibility	Accept that **you are fallible**: your initial view may not be the most defensible. Refusing this means you won't change your mind even for a better argument
2. Truth-seeking	Be committed to **earnestly searching for the truth** (or the most defensible position): examine alternatives seriously and allow objections
3. Clarity	Positions, defences and attacks must be **free of linguistic confusion** and clearly separated from other issues
4. Burden of proof	The burden of proof **rests on the one who sets forth the position**; if asked, they must give an argument. **Exception:** if the claim is well established or uncontroversial, the burden may fall on the challenger
5. Charity	When you reformulate an opponent's argument, express it **in its strongest possible version**, consistent with the arguer's original intention, and give them the **benefit of the doubt**
6. Suspension of judgment	If **no position is well defended**, or **two positions are equally strong**, **suspend judgment** (unless practical considerations demand a decision; then weigh the consequences)
7. Resolution	An issue is **resolved** when one position's argument is structurally sound, relevant, acceptable, sufficient and rebuts all serious criticisms. Then you are **obligated to accept** it, but **reopen** it if new evidence raises new doubts

"FEEL THE CLEAR BURDEN; CHARITY SETTLES RESOLUTIONS"

Fallibility · **T**ruth-seeking · **C**larity · **B**urden of proof · **C**harity · **S**uspension of judgment · **R**esolution.

! PRINCIPLE ↔ FALLACY LINKS (FREQUENTLY TESTED)

- **Shifting the burden of proof** ("it's true unless you can prove otherwise") commits the fallacy of **appeal to ignorance**.
- The **straw man** fallacy violates the **principle of charity** (it attacks a weaker, distorted version).
- Fallacies of **ambiguity** violate the **clarity** principle.

Why are so few issues resolved?

Someone may have a **blind spot**; be **rationally but not psychologically** convinced; be **rationally careless**; have a **hidden agenda**; want to **win** more than to find a solution; or be in **deep disagreement** (different basic assumptions). No argument is **permanently** successful. An issue may be reopened, but only because of **new or reinterpreted evidence**, not "the same old doubts in new clothing".

Exam Practice

9 QUESTIONS · LESSON 4.3

1 Salale University · Final 2015

Which principle of critical thinking is violated by the straw man fallacy?

A) Fallibility
B) Clarity
C) Suspension of judgment
D) Charity

2 Salale University · Final 2015

What is the principle of charity?

A) Assuming all arguments are valid
B) Rejecting arguments that lack evidence
C) Interpreting arguments in the most favourable way possible
D) Accepting arguments because of the arguer's authority

3 Salale University · Final 2014

Which principle of good argument is WRONGLY matched?

A) Structural principle: no contradictory reasons
B) Acceptability principle: always uses premises that are absolutely true
C) Relevance principle: reasons whose truth gives some evidence for the conclusion
D) Sufficiency principle: reasons sufficient in number and weight
E) Rebuttal principle: an effective response to serious criticisms

4 Hawassa University · Model Exam

"The burden of proof for any position usually rests on the participant who sets forth the position." To shift this burden by saying "my claim is true unless you can prove otherwise" commits the fallacy of:

A) Straw man
B) Begging the question
C) Red herring
D) Appeal to ignorance

5 Hawassa University · Model Exam

Two positions on an issue are defended with equally strong arguments, and no practical decision is urgent. Which principle applies?

A) Suspension of judgment principle
B) Rebuttal principle
C) Fallibility principle
D) Resolution principle

6 Haramaya University · Model Exam

Which principle of a good argument requires an argument to anticipate and effectively answer the most serious criticisms against it?

A) Sufficiency
B) Acceptability
C) Structural
D) Rebuttal

7 Haramaya University · Model Exam

An argument whose premises contradict each other violates the:

A) Relevance principle
B) Structural principle
C) Truth-seeking principle
D) Rebuttal principle

8 Injibara University · Model Exam

"I admit that my present view may be wrong and may not be the most defensible position." This attitude expresses the:

A) Burden of proof principle
B) Charity principle
C) Resolution principle
D) Fallibility principle

9 Injibara University · Model Exam

According to the resolution principle, once an issue is resolved it may never be reopened.

True / False

Answers & Explanations

1. D

Charity

Charity requires restating an opponent's argument in its strongest version. A straw man distorts it into a weaker one.

2. C

Interpreting arguments in the most favourable way possible

An opponent's argument should be "expressed in its strongest possible version" consistent with the arguer's intention.

3. B

Acceptability principle: always uses premises that are absolutely true

Acceptability asks for premises a mature, rational person **would accept**. The module explains that "acceptable" is preferred to "true" because absolute truth is very hard to establish.

---

4. D

Appeal to ignorance

The module says this is "arguing from ignorance": making a claim based on no evidence at all.

---

5. A

Suspension of judgment principle

If no position is well defended, or two are equally strong, one should usually suspend judgment.

---

6. D

Rebuttal

An argument cannot be good if it does not refute or blunt the strongest objections.

---

7. B

Structural principle

Incompatible premises can lead to any conclusion, so such an argument cannot even function as an argument.

---

8. D

Fallibility principle

Accepting your own fallibility shows you are willing to change your mind if you hear a better argument.

---

9. False

If new or reinterpreted evidence raises new doubts, one is obligated to reopen the issue. No argument is permanently successful.

CHAPTER 4 · LESSON 4.4

Characteristics of Critical Thinking

AFTER THIS LESSON YOU CAN

- List the basic traits of critical thinkers
- List the basic traits of uncritical thinkers
- Compare the two point by point

A **critical thinker** is a person who shows the features of critical thinking: certain **dispositions and attitudes, skills and abilities, habits and values**.

Critical thinkers...	Uncritical thinkers...
Are **honest with themselves**: acknowledge what they don't know, recognize their limitations, watch for their own errors	**Pretend they know more** than they do, ignore their limitations, assume their views are **error-free**
Regard problems and controversial issues as **exciting challenges**	Regard problems as **nuisances or threats to their ego**
Strive for understanding, keep **curiosity** alive, are **patient with complexity**, invest time to overcome confusion	Are **impatient with complexity**; would rather remain confused than make the effort to understand
Base judgments on **evidence**, not personal preference; **defer judgment** when evidence is insufficient; **revise** judgments when new evidence reveals error	Base judgments on **first impressions and gut reactions**; unconcerned with the amount or quality of evidence; **cling to their views**
Are **interested in other people's ideas**: read and listen attentively, even when they disagree	Are **preoccupied with themselves**; at the first sign of disagreement think "**How can I refute this?**"
Recognize that **extreme views** are seldom correct, so they avoid them, practise fair-mindedness and seek **balance**	**Ignore the need for balance**; prefer views that support their established views
Practise **restraint**: control their feelings, **think before acting**	**Follow their feelings** and act **impulsively**

Further contrasts in the module

Critical	Uncritical
Passionate drive for clarity, precision, accuracy	Unclear, imprecise, inaccurate thinking
Sensitive to egocentrism, sociocentrism, wishful thinking	**Fall prey** to egocentrism, sociocentrism, relativism, unwarranted assumptions, wishful thinking
Skilled at understanding and fairly evaluating arguments	Misunderstand or unfairly evaluate arguments

Critical	Uncritical
Open-minded; **welcome criticism** of their beliefs	Closed-minded; **resist** criticism
Aware of their own biases and preconceptions	Lack awareness of their own biases
Think independently; not afraid to disagree with the group	Engage in **"groupthink"**
Intellectual courage to face ideas that challenge basic beliefs	**Fear and resist** challenging ideas
Pursue truth; curious; **intellectual perseverance**	Indifferent to truth; lack curiosity; give up at obstacles

M THE MIRROR TRICK

Every uncritical trait is the **mirror image** of a critical one: honest ↔ pretending · challenge ↔ threat · patient ↔ impatient · evidence ↔ gut · listening ↔ refuting · balance ↔ extremes · restraint ↔ impulse.

Exam Practice

6 QUESTIONS · LESSON 4.4

1 Salale University · Final 2015

Which is NOT a basic trait of a critical thinker?

A) Keeping curiosity alive
B) Deferring judgment when evidence is insufficient
C) Recognizing one's own limitations
D) Assuming their views are error-free

2 Salale University · Final 2014

Give at least three characteristics of critical and uncritical thinkers.

3 Mizan-Tepi University · Model Exam

At the first sign of disagreement, Kebede always thinks, "How can I refute this?" This is a trait of:

A) the principle of charity
B) an uncritical thinker
C) intellectual perseverance
D) a critical thinker

4 Mizan-Tepi University · Model Exam

Critical thinkers regard problems and controversial issues as:

A) threats to their ego
B) exciting challenges
C) matters for gut reaction
D) nuisances to avoid

5 Wachemo University · Model Exam

Which trait does the module associate with critical thinkers regarding extreme views?

A) They ignore the need for balance
B) They recognize extreme views are seldom correct and seek a balanced view
C) They accept whichever extreme the group holds
D) They prefer extreme views because they are bold

6 Wachemo University · Model Exam

Uncritical thinkers tend to engage in "groupthink", uncritically following the beliefs and values of the crowd.

True / False

Answers & Explanations

1. D

Assuming their views are error-free

Assuming one's views are error-free is a trait of **uncritical** thinkers.

2. Any three matched pairs

Honest about limitations vs pretending to know more; judgments based on evidence vs gut reactions; listening open-mindedly vs preoccupied with own opinions; problems as challenges vs threats to the ego; controlling feelings vs acting impulsively.

3. B

an uncritical thinker

Uncritical thinkers are preoccupied with themselves and their own opinions and unwilling to pay attention to others' views.

4. B

exciting challenges

Uncritical thinkers see them as nuisances or threats to their ego.

5. B

They recognize extreme views are seldom correct and seek a balanced view

Critical thinkers avoid extreme views (whether conservative or liberal), practise fair-mindedness and seek balance.

6. **True**

Critical thinkers think independently and are not afraid to disagree with group opinion.

CHAPTER 4 · LESSON 4.5

Barriers to Critical Thinking

AFTER THIS LESSON YOU CAN

- List common barriers to critical thinking
- Explain egocentrism and its two forms
- Explain sociocentrism and its two forms
- Explain unwarranted assumptions, stereotypes, relativism and wishful thinking

If critical thinking is so valuable, why is **uncritical** thinking so common, even among educated people? The module first lists **many barriers**:

> lack of background information · poor reading skills · bias · prejudice · superstition · egocentrism · sociocentrism · peer pressure · conformism · provincialism (narrow, unsophisticated thinking) · narrow-mindedness · closed-mindedness · distrust in reason · relativistic thinking · stereotyping · unwarranted assumptions · **scapegoating** (blaming the innocent) · **rationalization** (inventing excuses to avoid facing our real motives)

It then examines **five that are especially powerful**:

> **M** **"EVERY STUDENT USES REAL WISDOM"**
>
> **E**gocentrism · **S**ociocentrism · **U**nwarranted assumptions and stereotypes · **R**elativistic thinking · **W**ishful thinking.

4.5.1 Egocentrism: self-centred thinking

> **D** **EGOCENTRISM**
>
> **The tendency to see reality as centred on oneself.** Egocentrics view their own interests, ideas and values as superior to everyone else's. All of us are affected to some degree.

Form	Meaning	Example
Self-interested thinking	Accepting and defending beliefs that **harmonize with one's self-interest**: "this benefits me, therefore it must be good"	Most doctors support laws making malpractice suits harder; most professors support tenure; factory workers want advance notice of plant closings, while most owners do not
Superiority bias (illusory superiority, the "better-than-average effect")	The tendency to **overrate oneself**, to see oneself as better than one actually is	Thinking you are unusually self-aware and immune to self-deception is itself a sign of superiority bias

4.5.2 Sociocentrism: group-centred thinking

D SOCIOCENTRISM

Group-centred thinking. Just as egocentrism focuses too much on the **self**, sociocentrism focuses too much on the **group**.

Form	Meaning
Group bias	Seeing **one's own group** (nation, tribe, sect, peer group) as **inherently better** than others, and looking with suspicion on "outsiders". Absorbed unconsciously from childhood; the root of much conflict, intolerance and oppression
Conformism	The tendency to **follow the crowd**: to conform, often unthinkingly, to **authority** or group standards. The desire to belong can cripple our reasoning; under pressure people even doubt their own immediate experience

! SOCIOCENTRISM ↔ BANDWAGON

The **bandwagon** fallacy (Chapter 5) exploits exactly this barrier: the desire to belong to the group.

4.5.3 Unwarranted assumptions and stereotypes

An **assumption** is *something we take for granted, believe true without proof or conclusive evidence*. We cannot live without assumptions:

- **Warranted** assumption: we have **good reason** for it. You take an umbrella when rain is forecast; you go to class at the usual time; you expect a car with its turn signal on to turn.
- **Unwarranted** assumption: something **taken for granted without good reason**. It prevents us from seeing clearly.

Stereotype is one of the most common unwarranted assumptions. The word comes from the **printing press**: plates ("stereotypes") made identical copies of a page. To stereotype is to assume that **all members of a group are stamped from one plate**, judging a person by **group membership** rather than **individual qualities**. Stereotypes usually come from **hasty generalization** (meet one talkative South African → "all South Africans talk a lot"), and the media often encourage them.

! "ASSUMPTION" ≠ "UNWARRANTED ASSUMPTION"

"Unwarranted assumption means taking something for granted" is **false** (Salale): that defines an assumption **in general**. The unwarranted kind is taken for granted **without good reason**.

4.5.4 Relativistic thinking

D RELATIVISM

The view that truth is a matter of opinion.

Form	Truth is...	Example
Subjectivism	A matter of **individual** opinion: whatever I believe is "true for me"	Abdella: abortion is always wrong; Obang: not always wrong → both "true for them"
Cultural relativism	A matter of **social or cultural** opinion	Drinking wine is "wrong in Iran" but "permissible in France"
Moral subjectivism	What is morally right for A is **whatever A believes** is right	G/Meskel vs Eden on premarital sex
Cultural moral relativism	What is morally right for A is **whatever A's culture believes** is right	Polygamy "wrong for culture A, right for culture B"

Few people hold relativism in a pure form (almost everyone accepts that 1 + 1 = 2 for everyone). The **most common form is moral relativism**.

I WHY CULTURAL MORAL RELATIVISM ATTRACTS PEOPLE

1. **Deep moral disagreement**: ethics seems to have no rational way to settle disputes, unlike science and mathematics.
2. It seems to support **tolerance**: wars and persecutions came from people sure of their own absolute rightness.

! WHY IT FAILS (MODULE)

1. **Disagreement ≠ no truth.** People disagree deeply about whether God exists, yet whether God exists is not a matter of opinion.
2. It **does not necessarily support tolerance**: if your society is intolerant, relativism says you should be intolerant too.
   What it can teach: intellectual **humility**, which we can learn without accepting a "false and confused theory".

4.5.5 Wishful thinking

D WISHFUL THINKING

Believing something not because you have good evidence for it, but simply because you wish it were true.

People fear the unknown and death, so they invent comforting myths: healing crystals, quack cures, communication with the dead, psychic powers. "Throughout human history, reason has done battle with wishful thinking and has usually come out the loser."

Exam Practice

12 QUESTIONS · LESSON 4.5

1 Jigjiga University · Final

"For this entire semester, I've been playing and having fun every day. My studies are not doing well. However, I believe I can score an A next week." This mistake is:

A) Egocentrism
B) Wishful thinking
C) Self-confident thinking
D) Moral subjectivism

2 Jigjiga University · Final

Which barrier to critical thinking is the tendency to see reality as centred on oneself?

A) Egocentrism
B) Relativistic thinking
C) Sociocentrism
D) Wishful thinking

3 Salale University · Final 2015

Unwarranted assumption means asserting or taking something for granted.

True / False

4 Salale University · Final 2014

Sociocentrism hinders rational thinking by focusing excessively on the group.

True / False

5 Salale University · Final 2015

Critical thinking presupposes thinking by rationalization about positions.

True / False

6 Salale University · Final 2014

Which is NOT one of the impediments that play an especially powerful role in hindering critical thinking?

A) Egocentrism
B) Sociocentrism
C) Altruism
D) Subjectivism

7 Gambella University · Model Exam

Most factory owners oppose laws requiring advance notice of plant closings, while most workers support them. The module uses this to illustrate:

A) Superiority bias
B) Self-interested thinking
C) Cultural relativism
D) Group bias

8 Gambella University · Model Exam

"I'm sure I'm far more objective than most people; self-deception doesn't affect me." This attitude reflects:

A) Superiority bias
B) Stereotyping
C) Wishful thinking
D) Conformism

9 Samara University · Model Exam

After meeting one talkative South African, Bekele concludes that all South Africans talk a lot. This is a:

A) Warranted assumption
B) Case of subjectivism
C) Stereotype formed by hasty generalization
D) Case of practical inconsistency

10 Samara University · Model Exam

"Polygamy is wrong for culture A and right for culture B, because each culture's beliefs decide what is morally right for its members." This expresses:

A) Egocentrism
B) Cultural moral relativism
C) Moral subjectivism
D) Objective moral truth

11 Werabe University · Model Exam

According to the module, which is a problem with cultural moral relativism?

A) It shows that there is no moral disagreement
B) It makes everyone intolerant of other cultures
C) It is accepted by all philosophers
D) Deep disagreement does not prove there is no objective truth, and relativism does not necessarily support tolerance

12 Werabe University · Model Exam

"Conformism" as a form of sociocentrism refers to:

A) seeing one's own group as superior
B) the tendency to follow the crowd, conforming unthinkingly to authority or group standards
C) blaming the innocent
D) inventing excuses for one's motives

Answers & Explanations

1. B

Wishful thinking

The belief rests on a wish, not on evidence; all the evidence points the other way.

2. A

Egocentrism

This is the module's definition of egocentrism. Sociocentrism is group-centred thinking.

3. False

That defines an assumption in general; many assumptions are warranted. An unwarranted assumption is something taken for granted **without good reason**.

4. True

Group bias and conformism are its two main forms.

5. False

Rationalization ("inventing excuses to avoid facing our real motives") is a **barrier** to critical thinking.

6. C

Altruism

Altruism (concern for others) is not a barrier. Subjectivism is a form of relativistic thinking, which is one of the five powerful barriers.

7. B

Self-interested thinking

Self-interested thinking is the tendency to accept and defend beliefs that harmonize with one's self-interest.

8. A

Superiority bias

Superiority bias (illusory superiority, the better-than-average effect) is the tendency to overrate oneself.

9. C

Stereotype formed by hasty generalization

Stereotypes typically come from hasty generalization: a conclusion about a whole group drawn from a tiny sample.

10. B

Cultural moral relativism

Cultural moral relativism makes moral truth depend on what one's society believes. Moral subjectivism makes it depend on individual belief.

11. D

Deep disagreement does not prove there is no objective truth, and relativism does not necessarily support tolerance

The module gives these two problems. Relativism can teach intellectual humility, but that lesson does not require a false theory.

12. B

the tendency to follow the crowd, conforming unthinkingly to authority or group standards

A is group bias; C is scapegoating; D is rationalization.

CHAPTER 4 · LESSON 4.6

Benefits of Critical Thinking

AFTER THIS LESSON YOU CAN

- State what critical thinking teaches
- Name its three benefits in the classroom
- Name its three benefits in life
- Explain intrinsic and instrumental value

4.6.1 Skills and dispositions

Critical thinking teaches you to **raise and identify fundamental questions**, reformulate them **clearly and precisely**, gather and assess relevant information, reach **reasoned conclusions** and test them against standards, stay **open-minded** to alternative systems of thought, recognize your own **assumptions**, and **communicate effectively** with others on complex problems.

> "Critical thinking is what university is all about." University is not only about facts; it is about learning to **think critically**. Becoming a critical thinker is **hard work**, like "toning up your mental muscles."

4.6.2 In the classroom: three skills

University cares less about **how** you acquired your beliefs than about **whether they can withstand critical scrutiny**. A critical thinking course teaches:

1. **Understanding** the arguments and beliefs of others;
2. **Critically evaluating** those arguments and beliefs;
3. **Developing and defending** one's own well-supported arguments and beliefs (for example, writing a paper on ethnic federalism for civics class).

These are **transferable** skills: structuring arguments, judging sources and making decisions carry over to other subjects and to personal life.

4.6.3 In life: three benefits

#	Benefit	Explanation
1	**Avoid foolish personal decisions**	About profession, relationships, behaviour: think about life decisions carefully, clearly and logically
2	**Promote democracy**	Citizens vote and evaluate policies, so their decisions must be informed and rational. Many problems (environmental destruction, poverty, ethnic conflict, corruption, rights violations, displacement) were largely caused by **poor critical thinking**
3	**Personal enrichment, valuable for its own sake**	Most people believe what they are told (earth at the centre, demons cause disease, slavery is just, women are inferior). Critical thinking frees us from unexamined assumptions: *"This is what I've been taught, but is it true?"* This leads to an **"examined" life**, personal **liberation**, the ultimate goal of education

INTRINSIC AND INSTRUMENTAL VALUE

Critical thinking is **instrumentally** valuable (it helps us decide well and supports democracy) **and intrinsically** valuable (worth studying **for its own sake**, for personal enrichment). So "critical thinking has both intrinsic and instrumental value" is **true**.

Exam Practice

6 QUESTIONS · LESSON 4.6

1 Salale University · Final 2014

Critical thinking has both intrinsic and instrumental value.

True / False

2 Salale University · Final 2014

List at least three benefits of being a critical thinker.

3 Oda Bultum University · Mid 2017 E.C.

How does a deep understanding of logic and critical thinking affect one's approach to problem-solving?

A) By encouraging a multidimensional perspective on issues
B) By stifling creativity and innovation
C) By promoting reliance on superficial solutions
D) By limiting consideration of alternative viewpoints

4 Kotebe University of Education · Model Exam

Which of the following is NOT one of the three classroom skills a critical thinking course develops?

A) Understanding the arguments and beliefs of others
B) Developing and defending one's own well-supported arguments
C) Critically evaluating those arguments and beliefs
D) Memorizing facts for repetition on tests

5 Kotebe University of Education · Model Exam

According to the module, how does critical thinking help democracy?

A) By helping citizens make informed and rational decisions as voters and evaluators of policy
B) By making citizens accept every government decision
C) By encouraging conformism
D) By replacing elections with experts

6 Dire Dawa University · Model Exam

"Critical thinking skills are transferable" means that the skills learned can be applied to other subjects and to everyday life.

True / False

Answers & Explanations

1. True

It is instrumental (better decisions, democracy) and intrinsic (worth studying for its own sake and for personal enrichment).

2. Any three

Better classroom performance (understanding, evaluating and building arguments); avoiding foolish personal decisions; promoting democracy; freedom from unexamined assumptions and biases (an "examined" life); skills that transfer to other subjects.

3. A

By encouraging a multidimensional perspective on issues

Critical thinking looks at issues from different points of view and imagines alternatives. B, C and D are the opposite.

4. D

Memorizing facts for repetition on tests

Memorizing and repeating facts is "lower-order thinking". University aims at higher-order thinking.

5. A

By helping citizens make informed and rational decisions as voters and evaluators of policy

In a democracy the people have the ultimate say, so their decisions must be as informed and rational as possible.

6. True

The module says skills like structuring arguments and judging the credibility of sources carry over to many other contexts.

CHAPTER 4 · QUICK REVISION

Basic Concepts of Critical Thinking — at a glance

Chapter 4 in one view

Topic	Remember
Definition	Cognitive skills + intellectual dispositions to **identify, analyze, evaluate** arguments and truth claims
Five definers	Dewey (grounds) · Glaser (attitude + skill) · Ennis (decide) · Paul (meta-cognition) · Scriven (interpretation; like reading and writing)
8 standards	Clarity (gateway) · Precision · Accuracy (Rawls; garbage in, garbage out) · Relevance · Consistency (logical / practical) · Logical correctness · Completeness · Fairness
5 good-argument principles	Structural · Relevance · Acceptability · Sufficiency · Rebuttal
7 critical-thinking principles	Fallibility · Truth-seeking · Clarity · Burden of proof · Charity · Suspension of judgment · Resolution
5 powerful barriers	Egocentrism (self-interest, superiority bias) · Sociocentrism (group bias, conformism) · Unwarranted assumptions and stereotypes · Relativism (subjectivism, cultural) · Wishful thinking
Benefits	Classroom (understand, evaluate, develop arguments) · Life (decisions, democracy, own sake)

! PAIRS THAT GET SWAPPED IN EXAMS

- **Egocentrism** = self · **Sociocentrism** = group.
- **Group bias** = "my group is better" · **Conformism** = following the crowd or authority.
- **Logical inconsistency** = contradictory beliefs · **Practical inconsistency** = words vs deeds.
- **Subjectivism** = individual opinion · **Cultural relativism** = society's opinion.
- **Straw man → charity**; **shifting the burden of proof → appeal to ignorance**.